When I’m Having a Hard Day

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You Don't Have to Fix Everything Today

Some days are harder than others.

You may wake up feeling depressed, anxious, overwhelmed, irritable, scattered, emotionally exhausted, or simply unable to get started.

On those days, your goal doesn't have to be:

"Have a great day."

Sometimes the goal is:

"Make the next hour a little more manageable."

Start With the Basics

When everything feels wrong, check the basics first.

Have I…

Taken my prescribed medication?

Eaten something?

Had some water?

Slept?

Showered or changed clothes?

Been outside today?

Moved my body?

Spoken to another person?

Had a lot of caffeine?

Used alcohol, cannabis, nicotine, or another substance?

Been scrolling or isolated for hours?

These things don't explain every difficult day.

But they can make a difficult day more difficult.

Make Your World Smaller

When your brain says:

"I can't handle everything."

It may be correct.

So don't handle everything.

Ask:

What is the next small thing?

Not:

"Clean the house."

Try:

Put five things away.

Not:

"Catch up on work."

Try:

Open the email.

Not:

"Get healthy."

Try:

Drink a glass of water.

Not:

"Fix my life."

Try:

Take the next useful action.

Change Something Physical

When thoughts are stuck, change something around your body.

Try one:

Stand up.

Go outside.

Change rooms.

Take a shower.

Turn on music.

Stretch.

Walk for five minutes.

Eat something.

Open the blinds.

Put your phone down.

Sometimes changing the environment helps interrupt the loop.

Don't Believe Every Thought You Have on a Bad Day

A difficult emotional state can change how you interpret yourself, other people, and your future.

Thoughts such as:

"Nothing is going to change."

"Everyone is disappointed in me."

"I've ruined everything."

"I'm never going to get better."

can feel completely true in the moment.

Before treating the thought as a fact, ask:

"Would I see this the same way on one of my better days?"

You don't have to force yourself to think positively.

Just leave room for the possibility that your current state is influencing the story your brain is telling you.

Delay Major Decisions

When possible, a highly emotional moment may not be the best time to:

Quit your job.

End an important relationship.

Send the angry message.

Drop out of school.

Make a major purchase.

Stop treatment.

Throw away your medication.

Write the thought down.

Talk with someone you trust.

Sleep on it when it is safe to do so.

You can still make the decision later.

If You're Overwhelmed

Try:

STOP BREATHE CHOOSE ONE THING → →

Ask:

What actually needs my attention today?

What can wait?

What can someone else help with?

What am I expecting from myself that isn't realistic today?

A reduced-capacity day may require a reduced-capacity plan.

If You're Craving

Don't argue with yourself for the next six months.

Focus on the next few minutes.

Delay the action.

Then:

Change location.

Contact someone.

Eat if you're hungry.

Drink water.

Move your body.

Attend a recovery meeting.

Remove access when possible.

Use your recovery plan.

Remember:

A craving is an experience. It isn't an instruction.

If You're Isolating

Depression, anxiety, shame, and substance use can all encourage isolation.

Try sending one message:

"I'm having a rough day. Can you talk for a few minutes?"

You don't need to explain everything.

Sometimes another person simply being present changes the moment.

Use Your Personal Emergency Toolkit

Write this down before you need it.

Something that usually calms me:

Something that gets me moving:

A place where I feel safer or calmer:

A healthy distraction that works for me:

Someone I can call:

Another person I can call:

A reason I want to keep moving forward:

When a Hard Day Becomes a Crisis

There is a difference between having a difficult day and being unable to keep yourself or someone else safe.

If you are experiencing suicidal thoughts, thoughts of seriously harming yourself or another person, a potentially life-threatening overdose, severe intoxication, or another immediate safety emergency, get help now.

Call or text 988

The 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline provides crisis support in the United States.

Call 911 or go to the nearest emergency department

for an immediate medical or safety emergency.

If you're experiencing a substance-related crisis or believe an overdose may have occurred, seek emergency medical assistance.

You do not need to wait for your next appointment when something is urgent.

My Hard-Day Plan

When I notice I'm having a particularly difficult day:

FIRST, I will:

THEN, I will:

The person I will contact is:

If I'm still getting worse, I will:

If I cannot keep myself safe, I will:

Call/text 988, call 911, or seek emergency care.

The Ischys Takeaway

A hard day doesn't require you to solve your entire life.

Sometimes success is:

Taking your medication.

Eating something.

Getting outside.

Not using today.

Making the phone call.

Getting through the next hour safely.

Small actions still matter.

Notice Understand Choose the Next Step Reach Out → → →

This page is an educational support tool and is not an individualized crisis or safety plan. Follow your personalized safety plan when you have one. For an immediate medical or safety emergency, call 911 or seek emergency care. In the United States, call or text 988 for the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline.